



Enoch Godongwana

(go-don-GWAH-nah)

Minister of Finance
Republic of South Africa

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Aug 2021**

Enoch Godongwana is a pragmatic leader whose approach to economic policy is shaped by a lifelong instinct for balancing competing interests.

▣ A Negotiator's Instinct

Godongwana is fundamentally a dealmaker. His decades in South Africa's trade unions taught him to "accommodate the fears of the other parties," a phrase he uses to describe his approach to economic-policy disputes.

▣ A Realist's Perspective

Godongwana sees the bigger picture, refusing to waste time on improbable outcomes or dwell on setbacks. In December 2025, Godongwana said that South Africa would resume its G20 place in 2027 under the United Kingdom's presidency if excluded from the U.S.-hosted 2026 G20 process.

Godongwana's worldview was forged on the shop floor and in trade-union debates over socialism, not in economics departments. Asked whether communism continued to shape his thinking, Godongwana responded that there are practical problems for which "abstract ideologies don't hold."

WHY THEY MATTER

Godongwana views the private sector as essential to the country's economic stability, routinely underscoring a preference for public-private collaboration and a sensitivity to actions that damage investor confidence.

▣ Energy Opportunities

Godongwana understands that the government needs a fiscal regime attractive enough to encourage oil-and-gas exploration and production. He has resisted political calls to increase mineral and petroleum royalty rates because they would harm long-term sector investment.

▣ Energy Vulnerabilities

Godongwana is acutely aware that South Africa's energy dependence creates macroeconomic exposure. He describes the country as "a price taker because we are not a producer of gas or oil" and approved R17.2 billion in fuel-levy relief during the 2026 Hormuz disruption.

Even while leading a militant union, Godongwana opposed anti-business measures, terminating a major automotive strike because, as he put it, there was no value in "bleeding the industry to death."

MEETING WITH THEM

While Godongwana is affable and often disarmingly at ease in stressful settings, he engages actively with challenges, interrupting with a rapid "no, no, no" to correct a premise before he'll answer the substance.

▣ **A Debater's Exactitude**

Godongwana is exacting about precision and will correct a counterpart's framing before engaging with the substance. He sometimes hands the interviewer the problem and makes them supply the answer that helps him. In an interview in 2018, he stressed the importance of not "undermining my own positions."

▣ **A Lecturer's Reflex**

In exchanges, Godongwana tends to slow down the conversation to his pace. Similar to a university professor, he defines a term, distinguishes it from a near-neighbor, or breaks it into components, and only then makes his case. One of his common refrains is "let me start by taking a step back."

Corporate leaders in South Africa note that Godongwana dislikes formal corporate ceremonies or layered bureaucracy. He is known for putting top CEOs on direct text message or WhatsApp channels to resolve policy stalemates quickly.

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **PIC Board Standoff**

Trade unions in late August resubmitted the same three labor representatives for the Public Investment Corporation (PIC) board, despite resistance by Godongwana. The ongoing dispute threatens to delay the full stabilization and governance recovery of Africa's largest asset manager, which handles over R3.7 trillion in public funds.

▣ **New Development Bank Loan for infrastructure**

South Africa in late August signed two loan agreements worth a combined \$405 million with the BRICS-backed New Development Bank. The loans will fund the Magalies Bulk Water Supply Scheme, aimed at easing water shortages in six municipalities across Limpopo and North West provinces.

▣ **South African Currency Strengthening**

The South African rand strengthened in mid-August to its strongest level since the United States and Israel launched attacks on Iran on February 28, as rising gold prices and a weaker dollar boosted the commodity-linked currency.

▣ **Upcoming Local Elections**

South Africa's local government elections on November 4, 2026 are shaping up to serve as a key test for the ruling ANC, especially as it has been losing vote share and its grip on urban areas over the past decade.

NETWORK

While Godongwana has deep ties to fellow BRICS countries, his commitment to non-alignment translates into continued support for the United States and Europe and a studied distance from more provocative policies.

Godongwana became South Africa's director at the BRICS New Development Bank in April 2019 and later served as Chair of its Board of Governors until August 30, 2024. Yet, he maintains a non-confrontational approach to the United States, even during the Trump era, and pushed back on proposals for a BRICS common currency.

Godongwana is anchored in a powerful Eastern Cape African National Congress (ANC) network centered on President Cyril Ramaphosa's political coalition. He is also known for investing in the next generation of leaders.

Godongwana and fellow ministers Mondli Gungubele and Gwede Mantashe—part of what journalists called the "Chris Hani cabal"—fought a rearguard battle to sustain Ramaphosa when the president faced accusations of serious misconduct concerning a robbery at Ramaphosa's private Phala Phala game reserve. While Godongwana broke with his deputy David Maseko over a scandal at the state-owned Public Investment Corporation (PIC), he is close to up-and-coming junior Eastern Cape politicians and labor leaders, and gave up his ANC economic-transformation chairmanship so younger leaders could step up.

CONTROVERSIES

Godongwana has faced several serious allegations alongside persistent policy criticism from labor and political opponents.

▣ Canyon Springs Pension Scandal

Godongwana's most damaging controversy involved Canyon Springs Investments 12, a company 50 percent owned through his family trust that received over R100 million from clothing workers' pension funds. He resigned as Deputy Minister in 2012, maintained he entered the venture in good faith, and reached a full civil settlement with SACTWU including repayment with interest.

▣ Sexual Assault Accusation

In August 2022, a masseuse alleged Godongwana sexually assaulted her while he was at a game park. He categorically denied the allegation, stating he had never inappropriately touched, harassed, or assaulted anyone. The National Prosecuting Authority declined to prosecute the case.

Godongwana's proposal for a 2-percentage-point VAT increase in his February 2025 budget provoked a revolt from across the political class, including some personal attacks. Zwelinzima Vavi, general secretary of the South African Federation of Trade Unions, suggested that the finance minister has abandoned the economic principles of the movement that formed him.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- ▣ **Minister of Finance**, Republic of South Africa (2021 - present)
- ▣ **Chairman**, Development Bank of Southern Africa (2014 - 2021)
- ▣ **Head of Economic Transformation**, African National Congress (2009 - 2021)
- ▣ **Deputy Minister of Economic Development**, Republic of South Africa (2010 - 2012)
- ▣ **Member of the Executive Council**, Eastern Cape Province (1997 - 2004)
- ▣ **General Secretary**, National Union of Metalworkers of South Africa (1993 - 1997)

BIO

Godongwana's personal experiences track the arc of South Africa's post-apartheid political class: rural Eastern Cape childhood, anti-apartheid detention, trade-union leadership, and eventual entry into government. Born on June 9, 1957, in Cala, Eastern Cape, he earned an MSc in Financial Economics from the University of London in 1998—completed while already a senior ANC and South African Communist Party leader. He was detained under the apartheid State of Emergency.

▣ **Socialist Thoughts**

Godongwana has long mulled the question of socialism in South Africa, penning articles such as “Industrial Restructuring and the Social Contract: Reforming Capitalism or Building Blocks for Socialism?” in 1992 and “Social Democracy or Democratic Socialism” in 1993; his favorite joke from two decades ago was “I am red — so red, even my arse is red.”

▣ **Sartorial Tastes**

Godongwana has roughly thirty fedora-style hats, which he connects to Xhosa initiation traditions and an appreciation for older township style. He has explained that “in my culture as soon as you come back from the initiation school the first thing they give you is a hat.”

Godongwana is married to Thandiwe Godongwana, a businesswoman and corporate director. They have children, though the family keeps them outside public life. In an August 2021 cover profile, a South African newspaper reported that Godongwana “takes solace in books.” He speaks fluent isiXhosa and English.